

PTI

A-Z POLITICIAN

TEJASHWI YADAV, 32

Leader of Opposition; Ex-Deputy CM, Bihar

A successful political debut was par for the course for someone whose parents—Rabri Devi and Lalu Prasad—ruled Bihar almost uninterruptedly for 15 years as chief ministers.

Tejashwi Yadav won his first assembly poll in 2015 and started his political career as Deputy Chief Minister. But the honeymoon ended by July 2017 when Nitish Kumar dumped Rashtriya Janata Dal, and Tejashwi found himself warming the Opposition benches. Then, his father was sent to judicial custody, leaving the political greenhorn to lead Bihar's single-largest party.

The Lok Sabha election in 2019 was a nightmare for Tejashwi, when RJD drew a blank. However, a year later, the young leader bounced back, with RJD becoming the single largest party in Bihar, though falling short of forming a government. His success was significant and attributed to him alone, as he led his party without the overarching presence of his father.

Gone is the bit IPL cricketer, the reliance on being Lalu's younger son. Tejashwi has made it clear that he is a leader in his own right. He is projecting RJD as an A-Z party, representing everyone, instead of a solely M-Y (Muslim Yadav) one. He is the chief minister's staunchest critic, but was part of the 10-party delegation that met Prime Minister Narendra Modi in August seeking a caste census.

Even family members are not allowed to come in the way of his agenda, most notably his brother Tej Pratap. Be it his parents or siblings, he has dropped them from party posters to reach out to those who have shied away from RJD. Certainly a politician to watch out for. ■

– Amitabh Srivastava

FEAR OF FLYING He successfully overcame his aerophobia to lead RJD's campaign for 2019 LS poll

> **"The people of Bihar have expressed faith in Tejashwi's leadership. He gives them something new and engages everyone with his progressive vision"**
>
> **PROF. MANOJ JHA,**
> *RJD MP, Rajya Sabha*